



Social development is about how a child learns to get on with others and become part of a group such as a family, a playgroup, a community. Through play activities and being with other people, children develop their social skills. As they get older, they become more independent and learn how to fit into the group and what they do as part of the group.

Developing social skills:

Children develop their social skills by watching and copying other people and by practicing these skills themselves. Children learn and practice social skills while they are playing with other children and within their family and community.

When children are playing together, they are learning:

- To care for others.
- To share and take turns.
- To communicate with others by listening and talking.

- About themselves – what they can do, what they like, what makes them happy or sad.
- About other people and how to work well with them.

Children are often at different stages of social development even if they are the same ages.

For example, some young children have learnt skills such as sharing and other children of the same age may not have learnt how to share yet.

When children play together they learn social skills while they are playing. In early childhood environments, children have their parent or early childhood educators with them to encourage them to practice good social skills during their play activities.

WAYS OF HELPING KIDS DEVELOP THEIR SOCIAL SKILLS

- **Provide plenty of time and guidance for imaginative play**

Children will need ample time to set up their scene and assign roles: who is the cook, server, customer, etc. This negotiation time is valuable, and an observant caregiver will allow children to work out conflicts, collaboratively problem solve and find necessary props while interacting as little as possible. The adult observing this imaginative play can watch for kids who are hanging back or being left out, gently helping them join the others, offering the child phrases they can use to ask to participate, or assigning them a task that needs doing. The key is plenty of time for children to negotiate and problem solve.

- **Create space and opportunity for unstructured play**

While imaginative play can be observed and supervised, there is also much a young child can learn from unstructured and uninterrupted play time. The human being is designed to learn through play and imitation in early childhood. Caregivers can supervise **without hovering**. It might feel a little counterintuitive to someone actively looking for ways to promote a child's social development, but it's okay to take a step back and let children naturally work through social situations. Learning sometimes takes the freedom to make a mistake and learn from it—so try to resist the urge to intervene if things aren't going perfectly initially.

- **Honor differences in personality and temperament**

Along with openly and clearly identifying good communication and real-time emotions, it's also important to remember that every child is different and to honor their methods and preferences as long as they are not hurting themselves or anyone else. A child who is slow to warm up may seem unfriendly compared to a more outgoing child, but their need to be included is just as important. It's important for caregivers and educators to get to know the children as well as their families. It's really important for teachers to really understand each child's strengths and challenges.

- **Experience and discuss stories together**

The simplest activities are sometimes the best ones for encouraging social development, and storytelling is another primal human activity. Reading together, watching movies or shows as a family, and then taking time to discuss what you've all seen is a great way to model turn-taking, listening and respectful communication. This can be done with a campfire story, picture book or movie night on the sofa with lots of popcorn.

- **Seek insight from education professionals**

There are many resources online that parents and caregivers can access for fun activity ideas. there is a wealth of resources that professionals can offer but cautions that the best methods and philosophies are those that fit the specific child. If you read something and it doesn't fit your child, keep looking.

- **Identify real-time emotions and model positive communication**

Children have a variety of abilities to recognize emotions or understand turn-taking. There are some kids who live in situations where they have limited experience in good problem-solving and other kids who struggle with speech and language. This is where adults and parents can step in and model awareness. Taking a moment to point out these specific reactions and behaviors helps kids know what to look for, regardless of their temperament or experience.